

quarterfinals. By some twist of fate, each player who beat an Indian was eventually beaten by another Indian.

The celebrations began the moment Humpy joined Divya in the final, ensuring India would take the top two spots and secure a pair of Candidates berths.

In recent years, the spotlight has largely been on India's rise in men's chess. Now, it's time to acknowledge how Indian women have steadily seized their place at the global high table.

Last year, Humpy finished runner-up in the Candidates, while R. Vaishali placed a strong fourth. The women's team matched the men's gold-winning performance at the Chess Olympiad in Budapest. The year ended with Humpy reclaiming the World Rapid title and Vaishali claiming a surprise bronze in the World Blitz Championship. Divya's World Junior Girls title, though significant, flew under the radar.

But her triumph in Batumi dwarfs all her previous successes. Seeded 15th, Divya beat five higher-rated opponents—among them former World Champion Tan Zhongyi and 2022 World Rapid winner Zhu Jiner.

Add to that her victories over her idols-turned-teammates Humpy and Harika, and Divya's campaign acquires a whole new dimension.

Though Divya's World Cup win will understandably overshadow other performances, it's important to recognise what Humpy accomplished during her run.

As the highest non-Chinese seed, Humpy outperformed her fourth seeding by accounting for Lei Tingjie, the 2023 World Championship runner-up, in the semis. She had earlier defeated rising Chinese star Song Yuxin and 2008 World Champion Alexandra Kosteniuk, now representing Switzerland.

Elsewhere, Harika impressed by defeating seventh seed Kateryna Lagno, the 2018 World Championship runner-up and a former World Rapid Champion.

Another commendable performance came from 39th-seeded Vantika Agrawal, who knocked out 2012 World Champion Anna Ushenina on her way to the third round. All told, this World Cup will be remembered not just for Divya and Humpy's dominance but for the grit and resilience shown by the Indian contingent when it mattered most.

In short, it was Indian women's chess at its finest, and the best possible global showcase of its rising stature.



How the Indians fared

Divya Deshmukh (Seed 15 | Rating: 2463 in June 2025)

Champion

R1: Bye

R2: Beat 79-Kesaria Mgeladze (Georgia, 2226) — 1.5–0.5

R3: Beat 18-Teodora Injac (Serbia, 2457) — 1.5–0.5

Pre-QF: Beat 2-Zhu Jiner (China, 2547) — 2.5–1.5

QF: Beat 10-D. Harika (India, 2483) — 3–1

SF: Beat 3-Tan Zhongyi (China, 2546) — 1.5–0.5

Final: Beat 4-K. Humpy (India, 2543) — 2.5–1.5

Koneru Humpy (Seed 5 | Rating: 2543)

Runner-up

R1: Bye

R2: Beat 61-Afruza Khamdamova (Uzbekistan, 2326) — 1.5–0.5

R3: Beat 29-Klaudia Kulon (Poland, 2407) — 1.5–0.5

Pre-QF: Beat 13-Alexandra Kosteniuk (Switzerland, —) — 2.5–1.5

QF: Beat 28-Song Yuxin (China, 2410) — 1.5–0.5

SF: Beat 1-Lei Tingjie (China, 2552) — 5–3

Final: Lost to 15-Divya Deshmukh — 1.5–2.5

D. Harika (Seed 10 | Rating: 2483)

Quarterfinalist

R1: Bye

R2: Beat 55-P. V. Nandhidhaa (India, 2343) — 1.5–0.5

R3: Beat 23-Stavroula Tsolakidou (Greece, 2428) — 4–2

Pre-QF: Beat 7-Kateryna Lagno (Russia, 2515) — 3.5–2.5

QF: Lost to 15-Divya Deshmukh — 1–3

R. Vaishali (Seed 11 | Rating: 2481)

Quarterfinalist

R1: Bye

R2: Beat 54-Maili-Jade Quillet (Canada, 2350) — 2–0

R3: Beat 22-Carissa Yip (USA, 2431) — 4–2

Pre-QF: Beat 59-Meruert Kamalidenova (Kazakhstan, 2330) — 4.5–3.5

QF: Lost to 3-Tan Zhongyi (China, 2546) — 0.5–1.5

Other Indian Participants

Vantika Agarwal

— Reached Third Round

Padmini Rout

— Reached Second Round

P. V. Nandhidhaa

— Reached Second Round

K. Priyanka

— Reached Second Round

Kiran Manisha Mohanty

— Lost in First Round